

A BUYER'S GUIDE FOR AMERICANS & CANADIANS

Buying a Condo in Playa del Carmen

Costs, rules, neighborhoods and what to check before you buy

Market data as of September 2026

Craig Verbeck

eXp Realty México · AMPI member · Riviera Maya agent since 2010

craig.exp_mexico.mx · +52 (984) 213-6512

Start here

Playa del Carmen is the Riviera Maya's busiest and most walkable city, and the most active condo market on the coast. This guide is written for American and Canadian buyers. It covers what condos cost right now, how the neighborhoods differ, how foreign ownership works, what closing really costs, and what to check before you commit.

The short version. Foreigners can own condos in Playa del Carmen through a bank trust (fideicomiso). Budget about 5–8% of the price for closing costs. A typical resale takes 45–90 days from signed offer to keys. Most foreign buyers pay cash or finance from home.

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Nothing in this guide is legal, tax or financial advice. Use it to ask better questions, and verify every figure with a Mexican attorney, a notario and a cross-border tax professional before you buy.

The Playa del Carmen condo market

Prices vary widely depending on how close the building is to the beach and Fifth Avenue, how new it is, and how it is furnished. These figures come from asking prices on active listings, not closed sales, so treat them as a starting range.

Typical asking prices by unit size

Unit type	Typical size	Typical asking price (USD)
Studio / small 1-bedroom	30–45 m ²	\$110,000 – \$140,000
Standard 1-bedroom	50–55 m ²	\$200,000 – \$230,000
2-bedroom	75–85 m ²	\$300,000 – \$360,000
Penthouse / luxury	100+ m ²	\$615,000 – \$1,000,000+

Source: Maya Ocean listing inventory, updated September 3, 2026.

Price per square meter by area

Area	Approx. price per m ²	Median listing price
Colosio (inland)	\$3,050	\$259,000
Playacar Phase II	\$3,100	\$404,000
Centro	\$3,570	\$216,000
Gonzalo Guerrero	\$3,850	\$335,000
Zazil-Ha	\$4,000	\$237,000
Xaman-Ha	\$4,670	\$211,000

Source: TuLugar active-listing data via The Latin Investor, updated September 21, 2026. Median prices depend on the mix of unit sizes in each area, so a higher median does not always mean a higher price per square meter.

Rule of thumb. Downtown condos generally run about \$2,500–\$4,200 per m². Genuine beachfront developments can reach \$5,000–\$10,000 per m². Inland neighborhoods can cost less than half as much per square meter as beachfront areas, with a longer trip to the beach.

Choosing a neighborhood

Centro and Gonzalo Guerrero

Walkable, full of restaurants and nightlife, close to Fifth Avenue and the ferry. Popular with buyers who want an active urban-beach lifestyle and strong rental demand. Expect more street noise.

Zazil-Ha and Coco Beach

Just north of downtown. Quieter, with beach access and local restaurants, without the downtown party scene. A good fit for buyers who want to walk to town but sleep peacefully.

Playacar

A gated community south of town with security and a golf course. It tends to attract families and long-stay residents more than short-term vacation renters, and prices run higher.

Colosio and Ejidal

Inland areas with the most affordable entry prices. A solid choice for budget-conscious buyers and long-term rentals, with a short drive to the beach.

How Playa compares to the rest of the coast

Area	Feel	Best for
Playa del Carmen	Dense, walkable, the region's commercial and social hub	Active lifestyle, year-round rental demand
Tulum	Design-forward and boutique, jungle and beachfront, wellness focus	Short-term rentals to design-conscious travelers
Puerto Aventuras	Gated and marina-centered, calmer	Families and retirees wanting security and quiet
Akumal	Bay and sea turtles, slower pace	Personal-use vacation homes
Puerto Morelos	Small fishing-village feel, low skyline	Playa's convenience without the density

CHAPTER 03

Foreign ownership and the fideicomiso

Mexico's constitution restricts direct foreign ownership of land within the “restricted zone,” which is 100 km from any border and 50 km from any coastline. Playa del Carmen sits inside it, so foreign buyers don't take direct title. Instead they buy through a **fideicomiso**, a bank trust that holds legal title on the buyer's behalf.

How the trust works

- A Mexican bank acts as trustee and holds the deed. You are the beneficiary, with full rights to use, rent, sell, renovate and pass the property to heirs.
- The trust is renewable in 50-year terms, indefinitely. The property never reverts to the bank or the government.
- Bank trustee fees typically run \$500–\$700 USD per year.
- Condos are usually the simplest fideicomiso purchases. Larger land parcels can add due-diligence steps.

The alternative: a Mexican corporation

Buyers purchasing multiple properties, land for development or property used mainly for rental income sometimes set up a Mexican corporation (S. de R.L.) instead. That removes the trust renewal and annual trustee fee but adds accounting, tax filings and setup cost. For a single personal-use or vacation-rental condo, most buyers are better served by the fideicomiso. Talk through both paths with your notario.

CHAPTER 04

The step-by-step buying process

1. Find the property and make an offer

A formal offer letter is signed, and typically a small good-faith deposit goes into escrow.

2. Sign the promissory agreement (contrato de promesa)

This sets the price, closing timeline and deposit terms, usually 10–30% of the price, held by a neutral escrow company.

3. Due diligence

Your notario and/or attorney verifies clean title, confirms there are no liens (gravámenes), checks that property tax (predial) and HOA dues are current, and confirms zoning and permits for your intended use.

4. Open or assign the fideicomiso

The bank trustee application is submitted. It usually takes 4–6 weeks, so it starts early, in parallel with due diligence.

5. Closing (cierre)

The notario prepares the final deed (escritura) and calculates closing taxes and fees, and both parties sign in front of the notario, who plays a much more central role than a closing attorney does in the US or Canada.

6. Recording

The notario registers the new deed with the Public Registry of Property, which finalizes your ownership through the trust.

Typical timeline from signed offer to keys: 45–90 days for a resale condo, longer for pre-construction.

CHAPTER 05

Closing costs and fees

Budget roughly **5–8% of the purchase price** on top of the sale price. On a \$300,000 condo, that is about \$15,000–\$24,000.

Item	Typical range	Notes
Acquisition tax (ISAI)	2–4.5% of value	Varies by municipality
Notario fees	1–2%	Deed preparation, review and filing
Fideicomiso setup	~\$2,500 USD	One-time bank trust setup fee
Fideicomiso annual fee	\$500–\$700 USD / year	Ongoing, billed by the trustee bank
Property registry fees	~0.5–1%	Public registry recording
Appraisal	\$200–\$500 USD	Required for tax assessment
Legal review	\$1,500–\$3,000 USD	Independent attorney, optional but recommended

Sellers typically pay the real estate commission, usually split between the listing and buyer's agents, so as the buyer you generally don't pay agent commission directly.

Financing your purchase

Financing is where buying in Mexico differs most from buying at home. Mexican mortgages for foreigners exist but come with higher rates and shorter terms than most US and Canadian buyers expect, so most foreign buyers pay cash or finance from their home country.

- **Cash purchase.** By far the most common route, and it speeds up closing considerably.
- **Home equity or HELOC in the US or Canada.** Many buyers tap equity in a property at home, since rates there are typically lower.
- **Developer financing.** On pre-construction projects, developers sometimes offer staged payment plans through the construction period.
- **Mexican bank mortgages for foreigners.** Available through a small number of banks and cross-border lenders, typically requiring 30–50% down, at meaningfully higher rates than domestic mortgages.

Whichever route you choose, get a clear written quote before you go under contract. Slow financing is one of the most common reasons a closing gets delayed.

What to check before you buy a condo

These are the questions that separate a good purchase from a costly surprise. Your attorney should confirm each one in writing.

- **HOA fees and what they cover.** Ask for the current fee, what it includes, and whether any special assessments are planned. In well-run buildings, HOA fees protect resale value and guest experience.
- **Rules on rentals.** Confirm the building allows short-term rentals and whether there are rules on guests, pets or signage.
- **Title, liens and permits.** Your attorney should confirm clean title, that property tax and utilities are paid, and that the building has its construction permits.
- **For pre-construction:** check the developer's track record by visiting finished projects, confirm the land title and permits before you pay, and make sure your payment schedule is tied to construction milestones and held by a neutral escrow.
- **Electricity.** Mexico's subsidized residential rate jumps sharply above a usage threshold, so heavy air-conditioning use in high season can raise a bill meaningfully. Ask for the unit's historical electric bills.
- **Hurricane readiness.** Hurricane season runs June–November. Ask about storm shutters, a generator and the building's insurance history.

Rental income: what really drives it

Rental returns vary widely by building, location and management. Don't rely on generic yield numbers. Work out the real figures for the specific unit: realistic nightly rate and occupancy for that building, minus HOA, utilities, property tax, management and maintenance.

- Walking distance to the beach, Fifth Avenue or a beach club matters more to your nightly rate than square footage.
- Turnkey, professionally furnished units rent faster and at higher rates. Include a furnishing budget in your total investment.
- Professional property management (cleaning, guest communication, maintenance) is close to essential for remote owners and typically runs 15–25% of rental revenue.
- Rental income earned on Mexican property is taxable in Mexico (see Chapter 09).

Tip. Ask any seller or developer quoting rental returns for the last 12 months of actual bookings and the management contract terms. Projections are not results.

Residency and taxes

Residency

Owning property in Mexico does not require residency. You can hold title through a fideicomiso as a tourist visa holder. Many buyers who spend significant time here pursue residency for convenience, including banking, vehicle registration and healthcare access.

Status	Typical requirement	Good for
Temporary resident	Proof of income or savings threshold; renewable up to 4 years	Extended stays without committing long-term
Permanent resident	Higher income or savings threshold, or 4 years on temporary status	Relocating full-time or retiring in Mexico

Thresholds are set in Mexican pesos and change periodically. Confirm current figures with a Mexican consulate or immigration attorney.

Taxes in Mexico

- **Predial.** Annual property tax, notably low compared with the US and Canada, often a few hundred dollars a year for a typical condo.
- **ISR.** Mexican income tax applies to rental income from Mexican property, regardless of where the owner lives.
- **Capital gains.** Due on sale. Exemptions and deductions can apply depending on residency status and documented improvement costs, so keep every renovation invoice.

Taxes back home

- **US citizens** must report certain foreign financial accounts and, in some cases, the fideicomiso itself (FBAR, and often FATCA Form 8938). Rental income is reportable on your US return, generally with a foreign tax credit for Mexican tax paid.
- **Canadian citizens** generally file Form T1135 for foreign property above a reporting threshold. Rental income is reportable in Canada, with a foreign tax credit for Mexican tax paid.

These reporting requirements apply whether or not the property earns income. Work with a cross-border tax professional before and after closing.

Cost of living and next steps

Day-to-day costs are generally lower than in comparable US or Canadian coastal markets, though imported goods and anything aimed at tourists can cost as much as at home.

Category	Typical monthly range (USD)
Groceries (local markets, 1–2 people)	\$300 – \$600
Dining out, moderate frequency	\$200 – \$500
Utilities (electricity, water, internet)	\$100 – \$250
HOA / building fees (condo)	\$150 – \$500
Private health insurance	\$100 – \$300 per person
Household help (part-time cleaning)	\$80 – \$200

Ready for the next step?

I've helped American and Canadian buyers through this process since 2010. If you'd like to talk through your budget, timeline or what to look for in Playa del Carmen, book a free 15-minute call.

Craig Verbeck, eXp Realty México, AMPI member
+52 (984) 213-6512 · craig.verbeck@expmexico.mx
craig.expmexico.mx · calendly.com/expmexico/craig

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